Beyond Presentism and Historicism: Understanding the History of Social Science

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The revival of interest in the social scientific past has stimulated a growing literature on the methodology of the history of social science. Existing "presentist" type histories have been criticized for their "Whiggish" assumptions about scientific progress. The critique of presentism is the product of a new school of historians of social science who advocate a "historicist" historiography. My paper is addressed to this discussion and falls into three parts. First, I review the principles of presentist and historicist historiographies, relating their methodological positions to their theories of science. Second, I take up the argument of the "new historicism" in more detail, criticizing its theory of textual interpretation and its theory of social scientific development. I conclude by offering an alternative historiographic model of social scientific development based upon a theory of science that I outline.

The new history and philosophy of science associated with the names of Paul Feyerabend (1974), Thomas Kuhn (1962), Imre Lakatos (1978), and Stephen Toulmin (1972) has revolutionized our image of the nature and growth of science. Instead of viewing science as a wholly rational enterprise moved by criticism and unfolding in a progressive manner, Kuhn, for example, underscores the nonrational aspects of science and the historical discontinuities in its development. The work of the new history and philosophy of science, especially Kuhn's *Structure of Scientific Revolutions,* has effected a major reorientation in the historiography of the natural and social sciences. In place of the "Whiggish" or "presentist" histories, which reconstruct scientific growth as a continuous cumulative progression of knowledge leading to the present, the new historiography, which assumes discontinuity in scientific change, proposes a historicist study of the past aimed at recovering the movement of science "from within" (Radnitzky, 1975). In the recent work of John Dunn (1972), Robert Alun Jones (1977), J. D. Y. Peel (1971), George Stocking (1965), and most notably Quentin Skinner (1969), the idea of a historicist historiography of the social sciences has been fully articulated. This essay offers a critical assessment of the "new historicism" and suggests an alternative historiographic model to both presentism and historicism.

Presentism

The question of how to study the social scientific past cannot be separated from the question of the nature of social science and its development. Presentism and historicism must both be understood as methodologies for

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the study of the history of social science and theories of science. Since historicism emerges as a critique of presentism, we need to outline presentism first.

Presentism assumes a continuity in subject matter and problems between past and present social scientists. For example, Parsons's claim that the work of both classical and contemporary sociologists proceeds from the very same problem of social order—the "utilitarian dilemma" of the contractarians—illustrates the presentist idea of continuity (see Camic, 1979). In the social sciences, the presentist assumption of continuity is frequently linked to a cumulation model of science.[1] As social scientists are oriented to the same subject matter and problems, the gradual improvement of research methods and conceptual clarification yields cumulative scientific progress. To the extent that the actual history of social science is perceived as discordant with the cumulation model, ad hoc explanations are offered. Thus, Merton (1949) points to the polarization between theory and research as the main obstacle to cumulation, while Randall Collins (1975) argues that the survival of romantic, aesthetic, and ideological notions of social science impede scientific cumulation. Finally, presentism shows strong affinities with a positivist idea of science.

The methodological principles of presentism follow from its implicit theory of science. First, the continuity between the past and present means that the problems and doctrines of the present may serve as the criteria for organizing, interpreting, and judging past ideas. Second, to the extent that the continuity between past and present is translated into a cumulation model, the past resolves itself into a simple division between those false ideas that have been refuted and those true ideas that have been subsequently incorporated into contemporary systematic knowledge. The history of social science may therefore be reconstructed by piecing together the increments of valid knowledge as if leading in a linear manner to the current state of knowledge (as an example of this, see Andreski, 1969:ix). Third, from the identification of science with empirically verified and logically axiomatic statements, it follows that a history of social science must disentangle ideological residues from valid scientific knowledge (see, for example, Turner and Beeghley, 1980). A presentist historiography reconstructs the history of science as a progressive movement toward the present, marked by occasional detours, brilliant anticipations, but in the main consisting of piecemeal contributions to current systematic knowledge.

Historicism

Our discussion of historicism begins with its critique of presentism and proceeds to its alternative methodological program for a history of social science. George Stocking has stated the critique of presentism succinctly:

> The Whig historian reduces the mediating process by which the totality of an historical past produces the totality of its consequent future to a search for the origins of certain

> present phenomena. He seeks out in the past phenomena which seem to resemble those of concern in the present, and then moves forward in time by tracing lineages up to the present in simple sequential movement. When this abridging procedure is charged with a normative commitment to the phenomena whose origins are sought, the linear movement is 'progress.' . . . The result is Whiggish history. Because it is informed by a normative commitment, its characteristic interpretive mode is judgement rather than understanding. . . . Because it wrenches the individual historical phenomenon from the complex network of its contemporary context in order to see it in abstracted relationship to analogues in the present, it is prone to anachronistic misinterpretation. (1965:212)

Historicism has two major objections to a presentist historiography. First, insofar as its aim is to legitimate current scientific standards and practices, presentism represents an evaluative or ideological attitude toward the past (see Jones, 1974:342; Peel, 1971:259). Second, by searching in the past for origins, for anticipations of and contributions to current systematic knowledge, presentism ends up advancing historically absurd interpretations (Skinner 1969:7–29). For example, past texts are organized and systematized to present a coherent position on some current doctrine or topic whose terms of discussion were unavailable to past authors. The historical absurdity of this procedure is heightened when the past author is praised or criticized for anticipating or not anticipating the full articulation of the doctrine and its present terms of discourse (Skinner 1969:10; for examples of such historical absurdities in sociology, see Camic, 1979, and Jones, 1977). The historicist critique amounts to the claim that presentism is not a genuinely historical approach to science but a form of mythology or ideology (Peel, 1971:259; Skinner, 1969:12–25).

Within the context of this discussion, historicism may be defined as the attempt "to understand the science of a given period in its own terms" (Stocking, 1968:8). Peel urges that a genuine historicist historiography "must be history 'as it really happened' " (1971:264). And Jones "stresses an understanding of the total sociohistorical context within which sociological theories have emerged—i.e. to understand the past, completely as possible, in its own terms" (1974:355). Understanding the past in its own terms means recognizing that the conditions and therefore the questions and answers of science vary historically (Camic, 1981:543; Jones, 1977:355; Skinner, 1969:52). This historical variability is particularly true of the social sciences where the constant movement of social existence yields new subject matter and redirects scientific interest. In contrast to presentism, historicism assumes discontinuity between the past and the present as a result of changing problems and subject matter. Expressing the doctrine of the historical discontinuity in the development of sociology, Peel maintains:

> In fact, however, each new emerging social context, in all its uniqueness, enlarges sociology's subject and provides not only a new subject-matter but new occasions for theorizing. So there is an important sense in which Marx and Dahrendorf, Spencer and Parsons, Weber and Bendix are neither competitors nor associates in theory-building. Very often the theories of the classical sociologists are neither true nor false in the light of the

> purposes which led *us* to theorize; because they are in large measure the attempts to grapple with a different reality, the answers to different problems, the upshot of different purposes. (1971:264)

The historicist doctrine of discontinuity is connected to an essentially empiricist image of science. Science is a response to particular problems raised by the concrete concerns of the given sociohistorical context, and as the social conditions change so do the problems and aims of science.

On the basis of its empiricist and discontinuous model of science, historicism requires a methodology aimed at reconstructing the particular and changing features of social science. However, it needs to be distinguished from another historically oriented approach—"contextualism," which seeks to explain ideational development by referring to the sociohistorical setting as its determinant (Jones, 1977; Skinner, 1969:42; 1976:214-216). In its Marxian and sociology-of-knowledge version (for example, Lukacs, 1962, and Mannheim, 1936), contextualism invokes antecedent "material" factors—class position, for example—as full explanations of ideational or textual meaning. Historicists maintain that though ideas need to be situated in their actual sociohistorical context, the text contains a line of questioning and argumentation that must be independently considered in order for its meaning to be ascertained (Jones 1977:295-296). Contextualism, with its proneness to an epiphenomenalist view of ideas, violates the integrity of the text. Asserting the integrity of the text, however, does not entail assuming its complete autonomy, as the New Critics and some structuralists hold. The new historicists seek to avoid both the epiphenomenalism of contextualism and the idealism of textualism by arguing that to specify the historical meaning of a text or idea complex one needs to recover the author's intention (Skinner, 1969:49; 1976:214; 1978:xiii; applied to sociology, see Hawthorn, 1976:6-7; Jones, 1977:297); one needs to know, for example, whether the author meant to criticize or to support the existing state of affairs (Skinner, 1969:45-49; 1972:403-404). To determine the author's intention it is necessary to have extensive knowledge of the existing state of affairs, particularly the available linguistic conventions, existing social arrangements, and idioms of discourse, in relation to which the meaning of the terms and arguments of the text can be fixed. The context, viewed as a field of meanings within which textual discourse acquires its specific sense, functions also to limit possible textual meanings, and therefore is the ultimate arbiter among competing interpretations (Skinner, 1979:49; Jones, 1977:292).

The new historicism is an attempt to formulate a genuinely historical study of social science. The past is to be understood "as it actually happened." To avoid the psychologistic and intuitive approach of nineteenth-century historicism, the new historicism proposes an intentionalist theory of textual meaning along with a "logic of validation" to supersede the present babel of interpretations (for a discussion of the link between intentionalism

and validation, see Hirsch, 1967). Though the new historicism shares with its predecessor the aim to redescribe the past, our contemporary historicists uphold the presentist claim that the overall direction of historical research is largely a function of current standards and practices (Peel, 1971:259; Skinner, 1969:5-6; Jones, 1977:284; also see the dissenting opinion of Camic, 1980:518, and the ensuing Jones-Camic exchange 1981:1133-1144).

A Critique of Historicism

The historicist program is a much needed corrective to presentism. To the extent that historicism counsels us to take note of the particular and changing features of social science, it is a giant step toward a genuine history of social science. However, the new historicism holds an unacceptable model of interpretation and an equally objectionable theory of science. In the following pages, I explain this twofold criticism and outline an alternative proposal for a historiography of the social sciences.

We turn first to the difficult problem of interpreting past texts. The historicists argue for an intentionalist theory of textual meaning. The intentionalist thesis states that to decode the meaning of the text the interpreter must recover the author's intention. Intentionalism does not entail a retreat from the text and context into an exclusive focus upon biographical details or the search for "motives" behind the text (for a discussion of the differences between motive and intention, see Skinner, 1972). Quite the contrary, in order to recover the author's intention it is necessary to situate the statements of the text in relation to their broader linguistic context so as to determine their "illocutionary force"—that is, what the author was doing in issuing a particular statement (on the concept of illocutionary force, see Austin, 1962). Thus, the intentionalist theory of interpretation moves back and forth between biography, text, and context in order to recover the author's intention. Against the intentionalist theory of interpretation, we offer three criticisms.

First, the intentionalist thesis assumes that the author's statements of intentionality fully and accurately comprehend the range of authorial intention and the significance of the text. In light of psychoanalysis, however, we cannot assume that an author has such privileged access to his or her own intentions. Recently, Quentin Skinner—the main architect of the intentionalist theory—has qualified his position in this regard (1974:284): he now maintains that in certain cases the author's stated intentions must be disregarded (1972:405). Although Skinner doesn't believe that this concession undermines the intentionalist thesis—since authorial intention continues to serve as the core of textual meaning—nevertheless, by acknowledging unintended meanings we are led to a much stronger claim for interpreting the text independently of the author's intention.

My second criticism of the intentionalist theory concerns the assertion of elements of textual autonomy. Reacting against the theories of intention-

alism and contextualism, French structuralism and hermeneutical theory have claimed at least the partial semantic autonomy of the text. Ricoeur (1971), for example, maintains that written discourse, in contrast to oral speech, requires the differentiation of textual meaning from authorial intention. "With written discourse, the author's intention and the meaning of the text cease to coincide. . . . Not that we can conceive of a text without an author; the tie between the speaker and the discourse is not abolished, but disintended and complicated. . . . The text's career escapes the finite horizon lived by its author. What the text says now matters more than what the author meant to say" (1971:534).

In a similar vein, Gadamer writes: "The text is part of the whole of the tradition. . . . The real meaning of a text, as it speaks to the interpreter, does not depend upon the contingency of the author and whom he originally wrote for. It is partly determined also by the historical situation of the interpreter and hence by the totality of the objective course of history" (1976:263-264). Nonintentionalist theories of interpretation illustrate the need to differentiate textual meaning from authorial intention by referring to the phenomenon of "unintended meanings"—what the author said is not what the author intended to say (see Hoy, 1978).

It is important to note that in his recent writings Skinner has once again modified his intentionalist theory. Skinner now distinguishes between "heteronomous texts" and "autonomous texts" (1976:222-228). Similarly, whereas Skinner once held that the main aim of interpretation is the recovery of the author's intention (1969:48-49), he now suggests that this is just one among the many tasks of textual interpretation (1975:405). Whether Skinner's qualifications save his overall theory of interpretation or indicate its failure need not be decided since, in my view, there is another more fatal flaw in his interpretive theory.

My third criticism is aimed at the objectivism of intentionalism and the historicist approach in general. Intentionalism maintains that, although past texts are conditioned by the author's intention and the sociohistorical context, the present interpretation of the past is somehow remarkably free of such determination. Historicists of course acknowledge the effectiveness of the present in the initial selection of historical materials. However, they assume that, inspired by the positivist spirit of selflessness, the interpreter can exercise sufficient methodological self-control to prevent the intrusion of present interests and attitudes into the objective reconstruction of the past. The other side to objectivism is a rather simple-minded copy model of interpretation.

Starting in the period between the two world wars, objectivism—the idea that it is possible to furnish a nonperspectivist or objective description of the world "out there"—has been subject to a massive critique (see, for example, Horkheimer, 1972; Husserl, 1970; Lukács, 1971; Pepper, 1942; Wittgenstein, 1958). The application of the critique of objectivism to a the-

ory of interpretation has been achieved, above all, by Hans-Georg Gadamer (1976; also see Palmer, 1969). Gadamer argues that interpretation is less a reenacting of the past or the subjection of the past to the present than a dialogue between the past and present. Substituting a phenomenological perspective for a realistic metaphysic, Gadamer says that the text is not a "thing in itself" with a fixed meaning to be recovered by suppressing the present. Instead, Gadamer reasons that the interpreter is always historically situated and conditioned by "traditions," prejudgments which structure the interpreter's perception of the past. The text is constituted and exists as an object of knowledge only in relation to the present context and standpoint of the interpreter—that is, in relation to the questions the interpreter asks and the assumptions the interpreter makes about the author, work, and context. To avoid reducing the text to but a projection of the present, Gadamer states that the text itself poses questions and responds to the interpreter's questioning insofar as the interpreter is open to the claims of the text. The truth of the text is revealed in the communicative process between the interpreter and the text. Moreover, the aim of interpretation is not to recover authorial intention but to reach an agreement about the topic discussed in the text. The nature of interpretation conforms less to a methodology of validation than to a dialogue.

The second part of my critique of historicism centers upon its theory of science, in particular its doctrine of historical discontinuity and its related empiricist idea of science. The doctrine of historical discontinuity states, to repeat, that in the social sciences the subject matter and problems of the past are different from those of the present. This is so because society is continuously changing. The historicist maintains that each generation of social scientists faces a unique subject matter and set of problems that reflect the particular sociohistorical constitution of society. Thus, in light of "the final uniqueness of each instance of sociology," Peel urges us to recognize "that theories are the product of particular purposes and a particular subject-matter" (1971:264–265). The empiricism of the historicist approach is in evidence in its assumption that the subject matter, problems, and ideas of social science arise from and remain embedded in their particular sociohistorical conditions. Expressing the viewpoint of an empiricist, Skinner writes: "Any statement . . . is inescapably the embodiment of a particular intention, in a particular occasion, addressed to the solution of a particular problem, and thus specific to its situation in a way that it can only be naive to try to transcend. . . . There are only individual answers to individual questions, with as many different answers as there are questions" (1969:50). Historicism denies a basic principle of social science as a discipline—the assumption that there are universal problems intrinsic to the nature of social science and that it is possible to articulate universally valid answers to these problems.

There are two arguments that could be advanced against the empiricist

aspect of historicism; I will confine myself to a discussion of their broad contours. The first states that unless one is prepared to deny the legitimacy of the claim of social science to develop systematic knowledge, the existence of general problems and generalized explanations of human behavior must be admitted (see Stocking, 1965:215). Without pursuing this further, I simply note that the recent work of Jeffrey Alexander (1982), Anthony Giddens (1979), and Roland Robertson (1974) argues forcefully for a general level of social science consisting of "general analytical presuppositions," "central problems," and "major axes of sociological analysis." Pointing to general problems and a general level of social science appears to contradict Skinner's claim that every statement or text has only a particular meaning determined by the particular intentions of its author and by its orientation to particular problems and to a particular audience. Without denying that texts embody particular meanings due to their specific context, problem orientation, and author's intention, I would argue nevertheless that Skinner is wrong in thinking that particularized meanings cover the full range of textual meaning. Although they are the embodiment of a particular intention, a statement or text contains presuppositions and intellectual claims of a general nature. Thus, although the statements of *Capital*, for example, must be understood in relation to Marx's intention to criticize the economists and the political economy of capitalism, the discourse of *Capital* makes general claims about the relation between the individual and social structure, history, human nature, the nature of science, and so on. Texts consist of statements and discourse that proceed at different levels of abstraction. Moreover, some texts, especially so-called classic texts—Marx's *The German Ideology*, Tönnies's, *Community and Society*, or Weber's *Economy and Society*, for example—though limited by the particular idiom historically available, nevertheless deliberately deal with problems, articulate concepts, and pursue a line of analysis whose interest and validity transcend their context (cf. Parekh and Berki, 1973:171). As one analyzes a text at the highest level of generality, the text assumes increasing autonomy from authorial intention and its originating context. To the extent that there is a level of textual meaning that refers to truly general problems and systemic knowledge, it then becomes urgent to reconsider the historicist doctrine of historical discontinuity.

Unlike the new historicists, the historicists of the late eighteenth and the nineteenth centuries (Burke, Herder, Humboldt, Müller, Ranke, Savigny) held that the other side to historical discontinuity is the continuity between past and present (see Mandelbaum, 1971; Meinecke, 1972; Popper, 1957; Small, 1924). Despite changing sociohistorical conditions, successive generations were viewed as inextricably linked through tradition—a heritage of common institutions and shared cultural commitments. Recently, in an attempt to revitalize the idea of tradition, Gadamer (1976) and Edward Shils (1981) have argued that insofar as tradition underscores the

context-bound character of experience, its embeddedness in and continuity with the past, it is indispensable for a theory of history. If we accept, as I believe we must, the notion of tradition linking the past and present, then our view of the historical development of social science needs to be modified accordingly. Specifically, we would need to be aware that frequently the particularity of idioms in which problems are posed and subject matter is defined conceals general interests and a continuity in questioning and argumentation with predecessors. I believe this dialectic of particularity and generality, or discontinuity and continuity, can be illustrated rather simply.

Studying, let's say, the problem of capitalism in Marx and Weber, we would certainly need to attend to the fact that Marx faced a different historical configuration of capitalism than did Weber. Moreover, the historicist could rightly observe that the particular social and intellectual context within which the problem of capitalism was posed varied between Marx and Weber. No doubt one could discern in Marx intentions and a line of argumentation different from those of Weber. Accordingly, a study of the problem of capitalism in Marx and Weber would necessitate specifying their different views of capitalism in light of their divergent contexts and intentions.

However, there are two arguments that point with equal necessity to the continuity between Marx and Weber. First, as Anthony Giddens (1971), Dieter Lindenlaub (1967), and Karl Löwith (1932) have persuasively argued, to the extent that Marx conceptualized the problem of capitalism in general historical, analytical, and ideological terms—for example, as a totalizing concept within which to grasp the movement of modern history, as an analytical argument regarding the priority of materialist conditions in explaining social action and order, and as a question of individual freedom and development in a capitalist society—there are evident points of continuity with Weber. An additional basis of the continuity between Marx and Weber derives from the similarity in their experience of capitalism. The continuity in their experience of capitalism reflects, despite historical changes, continuity in the basic institutional structure of capitalism and continuity in the perspectives in terms of which Marx and Weber interpreted their experience of capitalism. Moreover, to the extent that Marx and Weber pose the problem of capitalism in general historical, analytical, and ideological terms, and to the extent that their experience of capitalism remains representative of ours, their analysis of capitalism retains a contemporary significance. Alan Dawe has recently commented on the idea of the representative nature of historical experience. The continuity of experience, writes Dawe,

> links the world we live in today with the reflections on the worlds in which they lived. . . . For while not ignoring historical particularity, what makes their work live on is the continuing relevance of their concerns to our experience. When Weber speaks to us of his bureaucratic nightmare of a world, he is also speaking to us in our world. . . .

> Through the *creative* power of their thought . . . they reveal the historical and human continuity which makes their experience *representative* of ours. The point is always the link with experience. . . . As long as they continue to speak to *our* experience, to *our* lives and times, they live on. (1978:366)

Although the continuity of experience links their world to ours, there are two additional factors that actually account for the contemporary character of so-called classic works. First, classic works remain contemporary insofar as they contain ideological and analytical presuppositions and substantive insights that have a contemporary resonance. No doubt this would partially explain the contemporary relevance of Marx, Durkheim, and Weber in contrast to the largely historical status of a Comte, Hobhouse, or Sumner. A second explanation of the contemporary status of classics points to the formation and institutionalization of schools or traditions whose inspiration and perhaps exemplary works are derived from the classics (see Clark, 1972; Shils, 1970; Tiryakian, 1979). There is little doubt that the establishment of a school or tradition of social theory by Marx or Durkheim, and the failure of, say, Simmel or Tönnies to do so, is a crucial variable in explaining their differential impact on contemporary sociology. Naturally, these two factors explaining the contemporary relevance of classic works are related though they are distinct as well. This is so because the successful creation and institutionalization of schools or traditions entails—besides a powerful theory—other, nonintellectual considerations, such as the personal charisma of the group leader, a favorable academic and national milieu, the right appointments, a receptive and supportive extra-academic public, and so on (see Tiryakian, 1979).

To summarize, my critique of historicism is twofold. First, I argue against its intentionalist theory of textual meaning and interpretation. Historicism identifies textual meaning with the particular intention of the author and assumes a copy model of interpretation. I contend that an intentionalist theory of interpretation suppresses levels of textual meaning that in certain ways transcend authorial intention and context. Moreover, I argue that interpretation conforms less to a copy model than to a model of dialogue. Second, historicism takes over an empiricist and a discontinuous model of scientific change. The former, I maintain, contradicts the rationalist premises of modern science, and in opposition to the latter, I specify the logical and historical bases of a theory of continuity in social scientific development. By way of some concluding remarks, I offer below a model of the historiography of social science that integrates aspects of presentism and historicism while avoiding their defects.

Theory and History of Social Science

It has been my general contention that the type of historiography of social science that one advances follows more or less directly from one's view of the nature and growth of social science. Every historiography of

social science, in other words, presupposes a theory of science. Specifically, I argue that both presentism and historicism hold unacceptable models of social science and therefore cannot serve as a sound methodological basis for a history of social science. Presentism rightly underscores the intellectual continuity between the past and present, but it misrepresents the nature of historical development in the social sciences by assimilating it to an increasingly less plausible model of cumulative growth. Reacting to the gross violation of the historical record resulting from the Whiggish attempt to fit history into an inappropriate scientific model, historicism calls for a return to history "as it really happened." However, historicism builds into its allegiance to the historical record a false theory of historical discontinuity, that can be translated into a simple-minded empiricist theory of science. Historicism's chief error in this regard is to assume that intellectual continuity in the social sciences automatically implies a cumulative model of scientific growth and therefore a commitment to a presentist historiography. In the course of outlining a model of social science, I articulate a conception of the historical development of social science that specifies levels of continuity and discontinuity and that will therefore better serve us in studying the social scientific past.

In the diverse movements of the new philosophy of science, phenomenological and hermeneutical philosophy, ordinary language analysis, and critical theory, we find elaborations of what I call a postpositivist theory of science (Dallmayr and McCarthy, 1977; Giddens, 1977; Rabinow and Sullivan, 1980). Despite very significant differences among postpositivist articulations, their unifying idea is a multileveled conception of science (Alexander, 1982; Holton, 1973; Shapere, 1966). Without denying an empirical and logical dimension, postpositivist theorists point to nonempirical, nonlogical spheres or presuppositions—for example, Gadamer's "prejudgments" (*Vorurteilsstruktur*), Gouldner's (1970) "background assumptions," Holton's "themata," Kuhn's "paradigms," Pepper's "world hypotheses," or Polanyi's (1966) "tacit dimension." Simplifying matters enormously, we may speak of science as a two-tiered structure consisting of an "analytical" realm of hypotheses, empirical statements, logical rules, theoretical postulates, models, and explanations, and an "ideological" realm of reality-defining assumptions and epistemological presuppositions.

On the basis of a postpositivist conception of science, we can outline a model of social scientific change, confining ourselves to developmental patterns proceeding from the "internal" structure of science. Our most important revision in viewing the historical development of social science follows from the inclusion of the ideological realm in our idea of science. In the process of developing explanations of human behavior, social science projects images of self, society, and world, and builds into its theoretical structure assumptions of a moral, political, and metaphysical nature. By virtue of its ideological realm, social science furnishes material for personal iden-

tity, cognitive and moral order, and political belief. Functioning in part as an affectively charged world view, social scientific theory informs and shapes the frameworks of order, meaning, and identity of daily life. The ideological dimension of social science and its embeddedness in everyday life is the basis, I contend, of the noncumulative and nonrevolutionary nature of social scientific change. Briefly, the reason seems to be that ideological commitments at the most elementary emotional, moral, and cognitive levels are resistant to evidentiary and logical criticism. While this accounts for the noncumulative character of social science, its nonrevolutionary nature follows from the argument that as social scientific ideas become part of our taken-for-granted world and are therefore affectively charged and supported by practical interests, everyday life will function as a conservative force perpetuating social scientific traditions, or at least opposing revolutionary ideational changes. Hence, the ideological dimension of social science is the main source of its static, nondevelopmental character.

To this analysis, however, we need to add that the ideological configuration of social science is sufficiently general to permit changes in the analytical realm. Thus, while the ideological presuppositions of Marxism have remained more or less stable, its analytical component has assumed diverse formulations. From this we conclude that, while the ideological realm of social science tends toward constancy and stability, the analytical realm is susceptible to variation and change, including, at the more empirical and middle-range theoretical level, cumulative progress. It is precisely this two-tiered structure of social science that accounts for our contemporary perception of social science as static and noncumulative, yet also developmental and cumulative, and that links the history of social science respectively to the historiographic principles of the humanities and the sciences.

Assuming a multileveled conception of social science, I have proposed a more differentiated model of the developmental logic of social scientific change. Corresponding to its multiple levels are different processes of change, disclosing continuity and discontinuity between the past and present as well as aspects of cumulation and noncumulation. A history of social science that recognizes the multileveled nature of social science would have to attend to the differential developmental patterns of the ideological and analytical realms. Finally, in contrast to presentism and historicism, both of which render the past virtually meaningless for the present, the model presented here acknowledges the contemporary theoretical importance of the past in two respects. First, as Merton (1949) and Stocking (1965) argue, the past remains theoretically relevant to the extent that its ideas have not been incorporated into current systematic knowledge or that its questions and problems remain significant yet unanswered. Second, insofar as the ideological and analytical ideas of past works speak to present interests or are elaborated into schools, paradigms, or traditions that extend into the present, the study of the social scientific past will have contempo-

rary intellectual significance. If we speak of, or write about, the classical tradition, we do so because classical ideas have so penetrated our discipline that they remain an indispensable point of departure for contemporary sociological analysis (Robertson, 1978; Smelser and Warner, 1976).

ENDNOTE

[1] In the humanities, particularly in the history of philosophy, we find a different version of presentism. The unit of analysis here is provided by so-called classic works, which are assumed to embody timeless truths. Though there is continuity in questioning between classic works in the same discipline or area, their timeless status precludes cumulative development. Instead, the relation between classic works is that of a dialogue across centuries. It follows that the historian's main aim is to reconstruct the dialogue, thereby preserving and transmitting to the present age the embodied wisdom. It must be emphasized that the major architect of the critique of presentism, Quentin Skinner, works entirely in the field of the history of political philosophy, where we find, moreover, a long tradition of this type of presentist historiography. Skinner's critique was chiefly a reaction to this version of presentism and, in my view, its legitimacy is confined to the excesses of this presentist tradition. To be sure, historiography in the social sciences is not entirely free of this type of presentism, as Jones (1977) has shown. Nevertheless, there is simply no counterpart in sociology or anthropology, for example, to the idea found prominently in the historiography of political philosophy of a unified tradition consisting of Greek, Christian, and early modern classic works. Much of the historiography in the social sciences, in fact, highlights differences and discontinuities within the sociological tradition. In addition, the scientific orientation of the social sciences, with its commitment to change, if not progress, stands opposed to the ahistorical disposition of this type of presentism. Hence, because I do not see this type of presentism all that widespread in the social sciences, its critique, though welcome, is less applicable and forceful in relation to the historiography of the social sciences.

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